

- RAG Learning

3B.6 Comparative Theories

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3B: Global Politics — spec topics 1 and 7: Theories of global politics and Comparative theories

Exam Tip: This topic is tested directly by **Section B**: one **compulsory** 12-mark question on comparative theories (AO1 6 / AO2 6). It is the one topic on the route you cannot avoid, and the theories also supply the evaluative framework for every Section C essay.

This page covers two spec topics: **topic 1** (the theories of global politics) and **topic 7** (comparing them). Realism and liberalism are the two theories the specification names. They are not descriptions to be recited but *lenses*: the marks come from applying them to the developments covered elsewhere on the route.

Anarchy — the absence of any authority above states; not disorder, but the absence of a ruler.

Security dilemma — measures one state takes for its own security appear threatening to others, who respond in kind, leaving everyone less secure.

Balance of power — stability arising when no single state or bloc can dominate.

Self-help — under anarchy, states can rely only on themselves for security.

Relative gains — concern with how much one gains *compared to others*, which inhibits co-operation.

Absolute gains — concern with whether one is better off overall, which permits co-operation.

Complex interdependence — Keohane and Nye's term for multiple channels linking societies, with military force a less usable instrument.

Anarchical society — Hedley Bull's idea that states form a society with shared rules and institutions even without a world government.

Democratic peace theory — established democracies very rarely go to war with one another.

Hegemonic stability — order is most secure when a dominant power underwrites the rules.

Constructivism — interests and identities are socially constructed rather than fixed.

1. Realism

Assumption	Detail
Anarchy	No authority above states, so no one enforces agreements or guarantees protection
States are the primary actors	Rational, unitary, pursuing their own interests
Survival is the fundamental goal	Security comes first; other objectives are secondary
Self-help	States can rely only on themselves, so they accumulate capability
Relative gains	What matters is position relative to others, which inhibits co-operation even where all would benefit
Order rests on the balance of power	Not on law or institutions

Variants

- **Classical realism** — conflict originates in human nature: the drive for power is a constant of human psychology.
- **Structural realism (neorealism)** — Waltz. Conflict originates in the *structure* of the system rather than in human nature: anarchy alone compels states to behave as they do, whatever their internal character.
- **Offensive realism** — Mearsheimer. States maximise power because it is the surest route to security, so great power competition is inevitable regardless of intentions.

The **security dilemma** is realism's most useful mechanism: because no authority guarantees protection and intentions can change, states must respond to *capabilities* rather than to declarations. This explains how conflict can arise between states that would both prefer to avoid it — which is a more sophisticated claim than "states are aggressive".

2. Liberalism

Assumption	Detail
Optimistic view of human nature	People are rational and capable of morality and co-operation, so a world of "harmony and balance" is achievable; conflict is not inevitable
Anarchy is real but not fatal	Co-operation is possible and can be made durable
Multiple actors matter	International organisations, MNCs, NGOs and individuals shape outcomes alongside states
Institutions matter	They reduce uncertainty, lower the cost of agreement, make defection detectable and costly
Interdependence	Economic integration raises the cost of conflict and supplies alternatives to force
Absolute gains	States can accept arrangements benefiting others as well as themselves
Domestic character matters	Democracies behave differently — contradicting structural realism directly

Democratic peace theory

Established liberal democracies have very rarely if ever fought full-scale wars against one another, though they fight non-democracies readily. Proposed mechanisms: **institutional** — leaders accountable to electorates that bear the costs face constraints autocrats do not, and democratic decision-making is slower and more transparent; **normative** — democracies externalise habits of peaceful dispute resolution and recognise one another as legitimate.

It is a direct challenge to structural realism, which holds that the internal character of states is irrelevant. Qualifications for AO3: definitions of democracy and war affect the findings; the correlation may partly reflect shared Cold War alliances; and *democratising* states appear more conflict-prone than either stable democracies or autocracies, which weakens the policy conclusion considerably.

3. Divisions between realism and liberalism

Issue	Realism	Liberalism
Human nature	Pessimistic: selfish and power-seeking (classical realism)	Optimistic: rational, moral, capable of co-operation
Power	States pursue power; military power is decisive; relative gains	Power is spread among many actors; economic and soft power matter; absolute gains
Order and security	Order comes from the balance of power; security through self-help and deterrence	Order comes from law, institutions, trade and democracy; security can be collective
International organisations	Reflect the interests of the powerful and cannot constrain them	Reduce uncertainty, build trust and genuinely change state behaviour

A middle position: the “anarchical society”. Hedley Bull (1977) accepted the realist starting point that there is no world government, but argued that states nonetheless form a *society of states*, bound by shared rules, diplomacy and international law that most states follow most of the time. Anarchy therefore does not mean chaos. This sits between the two theories and helps explain why co-operation persists despite the absence of enforcement.

4. Applying the theories

Development	Realist reading	Liberal reading
The Security Council veto	Institutions encode the power distribution at their creation; the veto preserves the standing of the states that built the body	The Council supplies a permanent forum; its other work continues even when it is blocked
The WTO Appellate Body's	Even the strongest institution rests on the acquiescence of the	The rules-based system functioned for decades and shaped behaviour while it

paralysis	powerful; one state withdrew consent and disabled it	did
Climate agreement	Relative gains and no enforcing authority mean states fear bearing costs while rivals free-ride — hence weak agreements	Paris shows institutions can secure near-universal engagement through transparency and review rather than compulsion — though the US withdrew again in 2026
The rise of China	Rising capability produces expanding interests and friction with the established power regardless of intentions	Integration into the trade regime gives China a stake in the existing order; institutions channel disputes
The EU	Difficult for realism — members accepted supranational law and majority voting for decades	The showcase: institutions transforming the relations of states that had repeatedly fought
No great power war since 1945	Nuclear deterrence and the balance of power	Deterrence <i>plus</i> interdependence and institutional channels

5. Constructivism

Not one of the two named theories, but worth knowing because it supplies what both lack. Realism and liberalism take interests as *given* and derive behaviour from them; constructivism asks where interests come from, arguing that they and identities are socially constructed through interaction, shared norms and ideas.

Wendt's formulation — "anarchy is what states make of it" — is the key line: identical material conditions can produce rivalry or community depending on how actors understand one another. British nuclear weapons and North Korean ones present very different threats to Washington despite comparable material facts.

It explains change the other theories handle poorly: the most significant developments of the last century — decolonisation, the delegitimation of conquest, the European settlement — were changes in what states *wanted* rather than in what they could do.

6. Evaluation

Which theory better explains contemporary global politics?

The case for realism: the last decade has vindicated it. Great power competition returned; institutions were paralysed by the states that built them; interdependence was weaponised rather than restraining conflict; states are deliberately decoupling in strategic sectors, accepting economic cost for relative security. Its strength is parsimony — substantial predictions from few assumptions.

The case for liberalism: it explains the overwhelming majority of international interaction, which is routine co-operation realism treats as epiphenomenal — the trade regime, the EU, the human rights framework, the sheer density of compliance with international law in ordinary conditions. It also accounts for the absence of great power war since 1945.

Exam Tip: The strongest Section B judgement is that the two theories **explain different domains rather than competing to explain the same one**: realism fits the hard cases where vital interests conflict, liberalism the dense co-operation where they align. A system containing both nuclear deterrence and the European single market will not reduce to one logic. Theoretical pluralism is an accurate response to a system with several logics operating simultaneously, not a failure to reach a conclusion.

Quick recall

- Realism: anarchy, states as primary actors, survival, self-help, relative gains, balance of power
- Classical (human nature) / structural or neorealism, Waltz (system structure) / offensive, Mearsheimer
- Security dilemma explains conflict between states that both want to avoid it
- Liberalism: optimistic human nature, co-operation possible, multiple actors, institutions, interdependence, absolute gains, domestic character matters
- Complex interdependence: Keohane and Nye. Anarchical society (society of states): Bull — a middle position

- Democratic peace: robust finding, disputed mechanism; democratising states are more conflict-prone
- Constructivism: "anarchy is what states make of it" (Wendt) — explains change in what states want
- Best evidence for realism: the WTO Appellate Body disabled by one state
- Best evidence for liberalism: the EU, and the density of routine compliance